

Death of the dinosaurs

Just before the dinosaurs first emerged, Earth suffered a mass extinction that wiped out nearly 90 percent of all species. The planet took millions of years to recover. Then, 65 million years ago, virtually all dinosaurs were wiped out in another sudden mass death. What caused their mysterious disappearance?

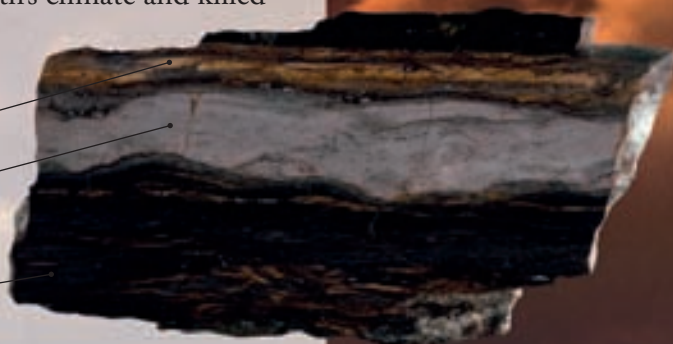
ATTACK FROM ABOVE

In 1980, an American scientist named Luis Alvarez made an amazing discovery. Studying rocks that formed at around the time the dinosaurs disappeared, he found that the level of iridium (a metal that's rare on Earth but common in meteorites) was 100 times higher than normal. He found the same high level all over the world and concluded that a massive meteorite or asteroid must have slammed into Earth. Such a huge impact could have wrecked Earth's climate and killed off the dinosaurs.

Coal

Iridium layer

Clay



DID YOU KNOW?

Not all animals perished. Those that survived included:

- Sharks and other fish
- Jellyfish
- Scorpions
- Birds
- Insects
- Mammals
- Snakes
- Turtles
- Crocodiles